01 — EXPERIMENTAL CHAPTER

The shape is not *the chord.*

What a guitarist's fingers know, what the notes reveal, and why the piano makes the same music feel different.



01 / RECOVERING A FAMILIAR CHORD

Start with something you can already play.

Play an open D minor chord on guitar: **xx0231**. You may know this gesture so well that you no longer think about it. But which pitches actually sound?

OPEN D MINOR · GUITAR

×	×	0	2	3	1

LOW E · A · D · G · B · HIGH E

SOUNDING PITCHES

D3 A3 D4 F4

The chord contains four sounding notes, including two Ds at different octaves.

CHORD TONES

D F A → 1 ♭3 5

These three note names constitute a D minor triad. Its minor third, F, distinguishes it from D major, where the third is F♯.

Three related, different descriptions

Chord identity	D minor
Chord tones	D – F – A
Actual guitar voicing	D3 – A3 – D4 – F4

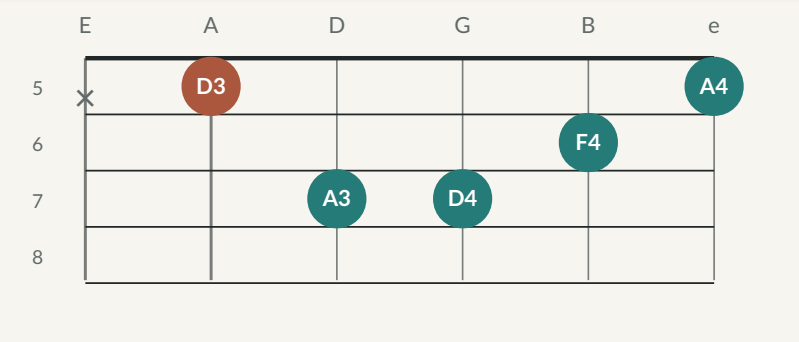
The first tells you what chord it is; the second names its constituent pitches without octaves; the third specifies which pitches this guitar fingering produces.

02 / ONE FORMULA, DIFFERENT INTERFACES

Move the chord. Watch the shape change.

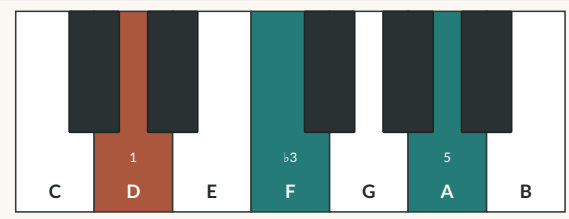
A movable A-minor-shaped barre chord at fret five sounds D minor. Move it up one fret and it sounds E♭ minor. On guitar the grip survives; on piano the same chord quality takes a very different shape.

GUITAR · MOVABLE BARRE / X57765



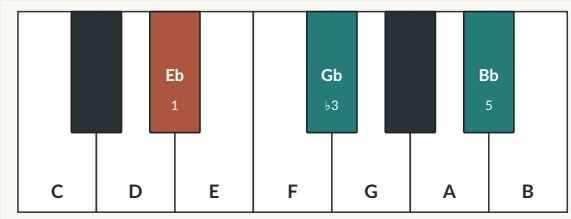
D minor: D3–A3–D4–F4–A4. One fret higher: E♭3–B♭3–E♭4–G♭4–B♭4.

PIANO / D MINOR



D – F – A
three white keys

PIANO / E♭ MINOR



E♭ – G♭ – B♭
three black keys

What stayed the same? The interval formula: **1–♭3–5**. **What changed?** Every pitch, its location on the keyboard, and the most convenient movement of the hand.

03 / MODES AS AUDIBLE ALTERATIONS

One changed note. A different modal sound.

Keep D as the tonal centre. Hold a D minor chord or play a slow Dm7 accompaniment, and compare the following two scales. Six of their seven notes are the same.

D NATURAL MINOR / AEOLIAN

D	E	F	G	A	B♭	C
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

D DORIAN

D	E	F	G	A	B	C
1	2	♭3	4	5	6	♭7

THE DIFFERENCE **B♭** → **B** lowered sixth → natural sixth

Hear the alteration, not just the scale

While D minor continues in the background, alternate **A–B♭–A** and **A–B–A**. Then play the paired two-bar cells. The tonic, the accompaniment and the surrounding notes stay unchanged.

AEOLIAN	**A – C – B♭ – A | F – G – F – D**
DORIAN	**A – C – B – A | F – G – F – D**

Try it without a metronome first. Listen to the quality of the sixth degree against the sustained minor harmony. The exercise does not depend on assigning emotional adjectives to the modes.

04 / WHY TONAL CENTRE MATTERS

Starting on D does not make the music Dorian.

C major and D Dorian contain the same pitch classes: C, D, E, F, G, A and B. But a pitch collection does not determine which note a listener experiences as the tonal centre.

SAME PITCH COLLECTION

C major ↔ D Dorian

All seven pitches coincide. What changes is the tonic and the musical context supporting it.

C	D	E	F	G	A	B

SAME TONIC

D Aeolian ↔ D Dorian

D remains the centre. Only the sixth degree changes; this gives us a controlled aural comparison.

D	E	F	G	A	B♭ / B	C

Which comparison answers your question?

Where do the notes come from?	Compare shared pitch collections.
What makes Dorian sound Dorian?	Keep D as the tonic; hear its natural sixth.

> Playing a C major scale beginning on D, over a C major accompaniment, does not by itself establish D Dorian. Harmony, emphasis, phrasing and the experience of a tonal centre matter.

05 / TRANSFER TO AN UNFAMILIAR KEY

Move the relationship, not the fingering.

The D-minor comparison was familiar. Now transpose it to F♯ minor. First construct the tonic chord, then choose the sixth degree from the formula, before consulting a keyboard diagram.

F♯ minor chord **F♯ – A – C♯** 1 – ♭3 – 5

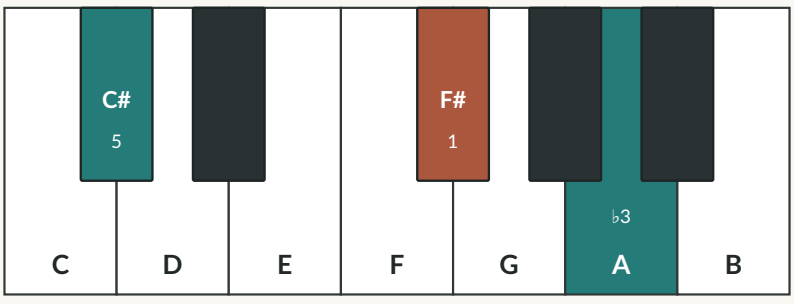
F♯ AEOLIAN

F♯	G♯	A	B	C♯	D	E
1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7

F♯ DORIAN

F♯	G♯	A	B	C♯	D♯	E
1	2	♭3	4	5	6	♭7

TONIC CHORD ON PIANO



The significant alteration is **D → D♯**. The musical relationship is the same one you heard in D minor; its pitch spelling and physical keyboard locations have changed.

06 / LEARNING CHECK

Can you recover the relationship?

Try these tasks without referring to the previous pages. The point is not speed or perfect technique, but whether you can find your way from a musical gesture to the relationships it embodies.

1. **Identify.** From open D minor on guitar, name its three chord tones and then its four actual sounding pitches.
2. **Change.** Turn D minor into D major by moving only one chord tone. Which one moved, and by how many semitones?
3. **Listen.** Play D Aeolian and D Dorian against the same Dm7 accompaniment. Identify the degree that changes and improvise a phrase that makes it perceptible.
4. **Transpose.** Without consulting the table, play F♯ Aeolian and F♯ Dorian. Identify their different sixth degrees.
5. **Compare.** What is preserved when a guitarist moves a barre chord up one fret? What is preserved when a pianist rebuilds the same chord formula a semitone higher?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER PLAYING

1. D–F–A; D3–A3–D4–F4. **2.** F becomes F♯, a semitone higher. **3.** B♭/B: ♭6/6 against D. **4.** D/D♯ against F♯. **5.** The interval relationships and chord quality; the notes and register change by a semitone, while the instrument geometry presents the new pitches differently.

Next: inversions and voice leading. Once we can identify a chord independently of the way we play it, we can choose voicings according to how their individual notes move.